the Chinese had suffered severe casualties the previous evening. He knew that the Chinese, devoid of artillery and with limited troops, would stand no chance whatsoever of overrunning Bomdila. Even without 5 Guards, the Bomdila garrison had six infantry companies (one Company of 1 Sikh LI was at Phudung, and 1 Company from 1 Madras had been sent to Dirang Dzong to protect Division HQ), along with adequate artillery, a couple of tanks and plenty of ammunition and rations.

However, based on the last information received from 62 Brigade and 4 Division HQ at Dirang Dzong, Kaul assumed that all the withdrawing troops from Se-la and Dirang Dzong were falling back on Bomdila. That is why the corps commander was adamant that the roadblock between Dirang and Bomdila be removed by 48 Brigade. Gurbax Singh had stalled for time with Kaul but now had no choice but to follow orders. Despite the fact that only an advance platoon of 3 JAK Rifles from the promised 67 Brigade had arrived thus far, against his better judgment, at midday, Gurbax Singh gave the mobile column the green light to proceed.

Swirling mist and low-hanging clouds in the valley through the morning had made observation of the Chinese difficult. A patrol from 1 Sikh LI had gone close to KM 9 but returned with no definite information of the enemy. As the mobile column comprising two companies of 1 Sikh LI along with two tanks of 7 Cavalry moved out of Bomdila towards Dirang Dzong, a dense bank of mist enveloped the depleted defences.

The lone company commander left in the Sikh LI defended area, Major Maini, was talking to his JCO when they noticed some people approaching from the direction of the Old Bomdila Pass. Flashes of gunfire followed by the sharp sound of automatic weapons announced the arrival of the Chinese at Bomdila. Maini was hit in the legs and brought down by the initial burst. His men dragged him into a bunker and then six men carried him to the medical station, further depleting the strength of the Sikh LI position.

About a hundred Chinese soldiers had appeared and they were engaged by a determined JCO commanding an ad hoc platoon that held them at bay for a short while. Lieutenant Pran Pahwa of 135 Heavy Mortar Battery, the FOO, immediately asked for fire support from the guns. The shells, fired from close range, exploded among the trees, but unfortunately the Bomdila defences were devoid of even basics like barbed wire and mines. The large gaps allowed the Chinese to manoeuvre their way through them and get into the defences, occupying the vacant bunkers and trenches. Their position